

HCS HB 2776 -- ASSOCIATE TEACHER CERTIFICATES

SPONSOR: Haley

COMMITTEE ACTION: Voted "Do Pass with HCS" by the Standing Committee on Elementary and Secondary Education by a vote of 12 to 5 with 1 member voting present. Voted to return to the Committee of Origin by a vote of 6 to 0.

The following is a summary of the House Committee Substitute for HB 2776.

This bill gives the State Board of Education (SBE) the authority to issue an associate teacher certificate to applicants that complete a background check and have a degree from a state-approved associate of applied science-level teacher preparation program or a program of a substantially similar nature that includes 60 semester hours from an institution of higher education. The teacher preparation program must include a literacy and reading instruction coursework, be accredited by the SBE, and includes a capstone project.

The bill creates a three tier certification process. Tier I and Tier II associate certificate holders may only teach in grades one to six, pay into the public education employee retirement system under Sections 169.600-169.715, RSMo, and have additional criteria that must be met to be granted a full certificate of licensure, including participation in a mentor program, professional development, and an acceptable score on the state-approved teacher evaluation system, as specified.

Tier III certificate holders may seek additional certification for middle school or early childhood, and pay into the public school retirement system under Sections 169.010 to 169.141.

The bill provides that schools may establish separate salary schedules for teachers with associate certificates with the minimum for Tier I and Tier II set at \$35,000 and the Tier III teacher at the minimum established under Section 163.172.

The bill specifies provisions for mentors for Tier I associate certificate holders that may receive additional compensation or release time and includes time for observations.

This bill requires that after 10 years, and every two years after that, the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education will

provide to the Joint Committee on Public Education a report on the effectiveness of the associate teacher process and make recommendations for legislative change.

The following is a summary of the public testimony from the committee hearing. The testimony was based on the introduced version of the bill.

PROPONENTS: Supporters say that there is a need for additional teachers as there are currently many unqualified individuals that are serving as the teacher of record due to shortages. This language would create an alternative route with additional quality training and educational pedagogy. This bill gives an opportunity at a much lower cost for many that may want to enter into education.

Testifying in person for the bill were Representative Haley; Matt Davis, Eldon School District; Tennille Banner, Green City R-1; Jerrod Wheeler, Knob Noster Public Schools; Brent Bates, State Fair Community College; and Mo Community College Association.

OPPONENTS: Those who oppose the bill say that currently there are systems in place and opportunities for students that are interested in working in education while pursuing a degree. Working in school districts while getting an education is very beneficial for both the student and the institution. The shortage of teachers is not because there is a lack of pathways but rather a lack of respect and resources, adding a lower quality opportunity will diminish the quality of educators.

Testifying in person against the bill were Missouri Independent Colleges; University of MO; Barri Tinkler, Missouri State University; Council on Public Higher Education; Joshua Heimsoth; and Dr. Tim Wall.

Written testimony has been submitted for this bill. The full written testimony and witnesses testifying online can be found under Testimony on the bill page on the House website.